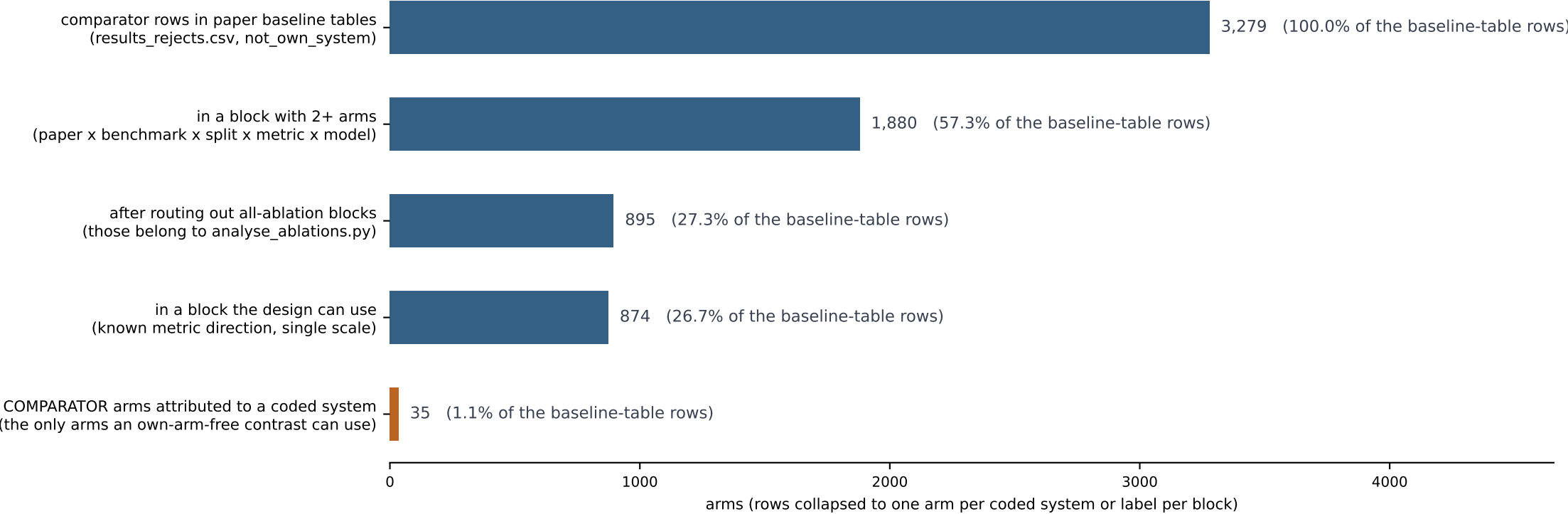


Within-paper comparison blocks: what survives to carry a design contrast
643 blocks with 2+ arms -> 332 after ablation-only blocks are routed out -> 7 with two or more coded comparator arms



The block is the unit: one paper x benchmark x split x metric x model, so one team, one protocol and one model are held fixed by construction. The binding constraint is not the number of blocks (332 of them survive) but **ATTRIBUTION**: only 35 of 819 comparator arms carry a name that resolves to a coded system at the conservative threshold, because a baseline table mostly names bare models, paper-internal configurations and ablations rather than third-party harnesses. An unattributed arm is kept in the block as an anonymous comparator - it establishes the protocol's difficulty and it enters the within-block standardisation - but it carries no design vector, so it cannot enter a contrast. **OWN-ARM BIAS**, the confound that dominates this design: in a paper's own baseline table the authors' system is the one they tuned, while the comparators are usually run at default settings by people who did not build them, and the table exists to show the authors' system winning. 'The paper's own system wins' is therefore close to tautological. The headline estimates here **EXCLUDE** the authors' own arm and compare comparator arms with each other; the version including that arm is reported separately and is **OPTIMISTICALLY BIASED**. Scaffold drift (docs/benchmark_caveats.md sec. 5) is reduced but not removed: the block holds one team, one protocol, one benchmark, one split, one metric and one model fixed, so the cross-paper protocol difference is gone, but the rival was run by the reporting paper at some commit while HARNESS-DB codes it at a pinned commit, which may be a different one. That is measurement error on the design variable; it attenuates towards zero, so every effect is a **LOWER BOUND** on magnitude. Reporting is also self-selected (sec. 3): which rivals appear in a table is the authors' choice. Associational only; no causal reading is supported.